

Securing public Wi-Fi connections

Public wireless networks are inherently untrusted – attackers can eavesdrop on your traffic, run “evil twin” hotspots that impersonate legitimate SSIDs, or intercept credentials via rogue access points. Automated “Auto-join” settings can connect you to malicious networks without notice, exposing passwords, emails, and banking sessions. Even HTTPS sites can be spoofed if DNS is poisoned or certificates are faked.



Step-by-step: Safe Wi-Fi practices

1. Verify network legitimacy

- Always confirm the exact SSID with staff (e.g., “CoffeeShop_Guest”) before connecting.

2. Disable auto-join and forget networks

- **iOS:** Settings → Wi-Fi → Tap “i” → Auto-Join: Off, then tap “Forget This Network.”
- **Android:** Settings → Network & Internet → Wi-Fi → Saved networks → Select → Forget; disable “Connect to open networks”.

3. Turn off file sharing and network discovery

- **iOS:** Settings → General → AirDrop → Receiving Off.
- **Android:** Settings → Connections → More connection settings → Disable “Nearby device scanning.”

4. Use HTTPS-only browsing

- Install browser extensions or apps enforcing HTTPS (e.g., HTTPS Everywhere).

5. Limit sensitive transactions

- Avoid logging into banking or entering payment info – save those for mobile data or your VPN tunnel.

Illustration: At Mumbai’s Chhatrapati Shivaji Café, travelers reported a fake “Chhatrapati_Free_WiFi” network. By confirming with staff and disabling Auto-Join, they avoided credential theft.

Configuring mobile VPNs

A VPN encrypts your device’s traffic end-to-end, preventing local attackers or network providers from snooping on your data – even on compromised public networks. Reliable VPNs also mask your IP, mitigating targeted tracking.

Step-by-step: Manual VPN setup on iOS

1. Choose a trusted VPN provider

- Look for audited, no-log services supporting IKEv2 or WireGuard (e.g., ProtonVPN, NordVPN).

2. Download configuration profiles

- From the provider’s website, install the [.mobileconfig](#) profile.

3. Import and authenticate

- Settings → General → VPN → Add VPN Configuration → Profile appears. Enter your credentials (username/password or certificate).

4. Enable “Connect On Demand”

- In the VPN configuration, toggle Connect On Demand so that any untrusted Wi-Fi automatically triggers the VPN.

5. Verify encryption

- When connected, look for the VPN icon in the status bar and perform an IP leak test via a web check (eg: [ipleak.net](#)).



Step-by-step: Manual VPN setup on Android

1. Select VPN protocol

- For best privacy and performance, choose WireGuard or OpenVPN over L2TP/IPSec.

2. Install the official app

- Download from Google Play or import an [.ovpn](#) file via Settings → Network & Internet → VPN.